

GIDF 2026 class descriptions:

12:00 – 16:00 | Technique & Tools Lab: Pushing the boundaries of Rajasthani Folk - Colleena Shakti

To embody a folk dance is to imbibe a feeling, a view of life, a sense of humor - the abstract qualities of a culture. This workshop will be an exploration of Rajasthani dance techniques from various communities finding their common ground, and the self expression that expands out from this center. Reaching beyond mere imitation, students will learn choreographic tools to empower their creative range and self expression. Discover an approach that remains true to Rajasthani roots while building choreography in the lived present.

*Not included in any pass. Book separately.

16:30 – 17:00 | Spill the Chai

A pause to slow down and sip chai while sharing reflections and exchanging thoughts with fellow dancers and teachers—a relaxed moment of connection before returning to the studio.

17:00 – 18:30 | Bollywood Folk Fusion – Vaishali Sagar

Experience the infectious energy of Mumbai! Join the renowned Vaishali Sagar to learn a powerful, folk-inspired Bollywood routine that blends cinematic flair with authentic traditional groundedness.

18:30 – 20:00 | Garba Choreography – Shampa Gopikrishna

Dive into the circular rhythm of Gujarat. This high-energy session focuses on the grace and stamina of Garba, teaching you a dynamic choreography that celebrates community, spirit, and footwork.

20:00 – 20:15 | Costume Workshop: Kalbeliya Styling

A quick-fire deep dive into the "Black Snake" aesthetic. Learn the art of draping, the significance of the embroidery, and how to style your jewels and dupatta for the authentic Kalbeliya look.

20:15 – 21:00 | Community Class: Kalbeliya – Swapnil

Kick off the opening party with the soul of the desert. Swapnil leads this inclusive, high-vibration community class where we'll learn the fundamental swirls and spirit of the Kalbeliya nomadic tribes.

BYO skirt, fabric or dupatta

Saturday:

08:45 – 09:00 | Rise & Riyaaz with Swapnil

A soulful morning invocation. Wake up the body and ground the mind through Riyaaz (practice), focusing on breath, posture, and rhythmic intent to prepare for the day ahead.

09:00 – 11:00 | Kuthu: The Heartbeat of the Streets – Desihop

Experience the raw, unapologetic energy of Kuthu, the vibrant folk-street dance of Tamil Nadu. Known for its explosive power and earthy footwork, this workshop breaks down the "rowdy" style and translates it into a high-octane Desihopchoreography. Expect sweat, loud beats, and pure, unrefined joy.

11:00 – 12:30 | The Martial Grace of Mayurbhanj Chhau – Shampa Gopikrishna

Step into the world of one of India's most striking martial art-dance forms. Originating from Odisha, Mayurbhanj Chhau is known for its stylized animal movements, sweeping leg extensions, and powerful jumps. Shampa will guide you through the fundamental Uli-Chali (basic steps) and the controlled strength required to master this mask-less, heroic dance style.

13:30 – 15:00 | Giddha: The Pulse of Punjab – Manasi

Manasi brings the golden fields of Punjab to Gent! Dive into the grace, playful storytelling, and rhythmic boliyan(couplets) of this traditional women's folk dance. This empowering session celebrates sisterhood and the vibrant, clapping rhythms that define the spirit of North India.

15:20 – 16:50 | Abhinaya: Training Expression for Dance –
Colleena Shakti

Indian dances stand out as highly expressive storytelling languages, so what are the traditional ways of developing the eyes and expression? From an Odissi classical dance perspective, students will learn conceptual methods of acting based on the text Natya Shastra, as well as physical exercises and training practices that target facial responsiveness and movement dynamics of the storytelling body. Students can expect some discussion on theory, seated practice toning the finer muscles of facial expression, as well as the study of Odissi dance phrases that demonstrate the tools of abhinaya.

Sunday

09:30 – 11:00 | Indian Fusion Bellydance – Colleena Shakti

Stylistically speaking, Indian Fusion movement vocabulary is inspired by cultural dances of India and the Middle East (including its modern evolutions). This dance bridges modern and folkloric Bellydance/Raqs Sharqi vocabulary with extensive postures and spins of North Indian classical and folk dance, intricacies of eyes, hands and facial expression from Eastern Indian classical dance and draws in elements of Central Asian dances as well. Woven seamlessly together, Indian Fusion Dance is both Ancient & Modern – expressing timeless qualities. In this course dancers get a taste of Colleena's unique fusion style through technique drills and compositions.

11:00 – 12:30 | Desi-Afro Grooves: From Mumbai to Lagos – Desihop

Experience the high-vibration synergy where the rhythms of Africa meet the flavor of India. This workshop explores the "Desi Afro" style—fusing the grounded, polyrhythmic nature of Afrobeat with the infectious energy of Indian street dance. Focus on body isolations, heavy bass-lines, and a whole lot of soul.

13:30 – 15:30 | Lavani: The Bold Heart of Maharashtra – Swapnil

Dive into the theatrical and feminine power of Lavani. Known for its rapid footwork and cheeky storytelling, this workshop

focuses on the traditional "Dholki" rhythm. Swapnil will guide you through the sharp movements and the playful Adaa (expressions) that define this vibrant Maharashtrian folk form.

15:50 – 17:20 | Bamboo Beats: The Rhythms of Cheraw –
Vaishali Sagar

Step over the bamboo with precision and grace! Explore Cheraw, the famous bamboo dance of Mizoram. This workshop is a masterclass in timing and coordination, where dancers navigate the rhythmic clanging of bamboo poles. Vaishali will teach you the intricate patterns and the soaring energy of this unique North-Eastern Indian treasure.

17:20 – 18:00 | One Last Gupshup (Closing Circle)

Stretch, cool down, and settle into the festival's final circle. Reflect on your experiences, share stories, say your goodbyes, and connect with teachers & fellow dancers through a relaxed Q&A. Take a piece of the festival home with you.